

emollient pulp helps relieve pain and inflammation, and it has been used to treat tumors, swellings, and gum abscesses—the fruit often being roasted before application. Figs are also mildly expectorant and, when used with herbs such as elecampane (*Inula helenium*, p. 107), are helpful in treating dry and irritable coughs and bronchitis. The milky latex from leaves and stems is reputed to be analgesic, and has long been used to treat warts, insect bites, and stings.

Related Species Research published in 1999 showed that an extract of leaves of *F. racemosa*, a native of northern India, had a marked protective activity on the liver in rats. The juice and powdered bark of the Central American *F. cotinifolia* are applied to wounds and bruises. *F. indica* is used in Ayurvedic medicine as a tonic, diuretic, and treatment for gonorrhea. *F. lacor* is used in Chinese herbal medicine to induce sweating, while *F. retusa*, which is native to China, Indonesia, and Australia, is used in the Chinese tradition to treat toothache and tooth decay. See also banyan tree (*F. benghalensis*, preceding entry) and peepal (*F. religiosa*, following entry).

Cautions The latex is toxic and should not be used internally. Applied to the skin, it may cause an allergic reaction to sunlight.

Ficus religiosa (Moraceae) Peepal

Description Tree growing to around 26 ft (8 m) with large, leathery, heart-shaped leaves and purple fruit growing in pairs.

Habitat & Cultivation Peepal grows in northern and central India, in forests, and alongside water. It is also widely cultivated throughout the subcontinent and southern Asia. The fruit is gathered when ripe.

Parts Used Fruit, leaves, bark, latex.

Constituents The fruit contains fruit sugars, flavonoids, and enzymes.

History & Folklore Sacred to Hindus and Buddhists, the peepal is the tree under which the Buddha attained enlightenment. It is a long-living tree; a peepal in Sri Lanka is thought to be over 2,000 years old.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Peepal's uses are similar to those of the banyan (*F. benghalensis*, p. 211). Its astringent bark and leaves are taken for diarrhea and dysentery, whereas the leaves alone are used for constipation. The leaves are applied with ghee (clarified butter) as a poultice to boils and to swollen salivary glands in mumps. The powdered fruit may be taken for asthma and the latex is used to treat warts.

Related Species See preceding entries, fig (*F. carica*) and banyan tree (*F. benghalensis*).

Foeniculum vulgare (Apiaceae) Fennel

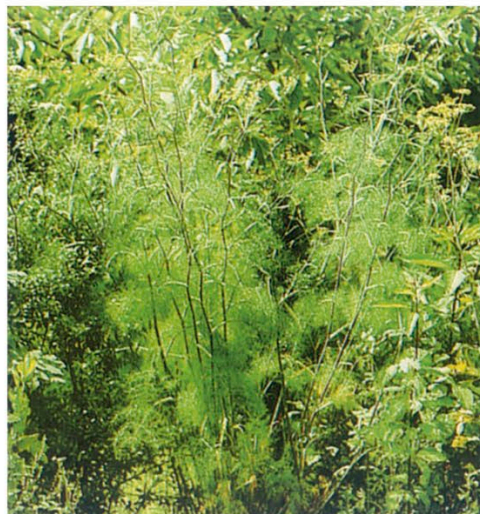
Description Aromatic perennial growing to about 5 ft (1.5 m). Has dark green, feathery leaves, umbels of yellow flowers, and small, ridged, oval-shaped seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the Mediterranean region, fennel is now cultivated in temperate regions around the world. The seeds are gathered in autumn.

Parts Used Seeds, essential oil.

Constituents “Sweet” fennel seeds contain about 8% volatile oil (about 80% anethole, plus fenchone and methylchavicol), flavonoids, coumarins (including bergapten), and sterols. The volatile oil relieves gas and is antispasmodic. “Bitter” fennel seeds contain significantly higher levels of fenchone.

History & Folklore Dioscorides, in the 1st century CE, states that “the juice, when put into the eye, aids vision, and into the ear, kills the worms (i.e. bacteria) that develop there.”



Fennel has a long history of use as a remedy for ailments of the digestive tract.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The primary use of fennel seeds is to relieve bloating, but they also settle stomach pain, stimulate the appetite, and are diuretic and anti-inflammatory. Like anise (*Pimpinella anisum*, p. 248) and caraway (*Carum carvi*, p. 184), the seeds make an excellent infusion for settling digestion and reducing abdominal distension. The seeds help in the treatment of kidney stones, and, combined with urinary antiseptics such as uva-ursi (*Arctostaphylos uva-ursi*, p. 170), make an effective treatment for cystitis. An infusion of the seeds may be taken as a gargle for sore throats and as a mild expectorant. Fennel is safe for children when taken at a low dose and, as an infusion or syrup, can be given for colic and painful teething in babies. Fennel increases breast-milk production and the herb is still used as an

eyewash for sore eyes and conjunctivitis. The seeds have a longstanding reputation as an aid to weight loss and to longevity. Essential oil from the sweet variety is used for its digestive and relaxing properties. It also has estrogenic activity and may prove helpful in relieving menopausal symptoms.

Cautions Fennel seeds are potentially toxic; do not exceed the recommended dose. Do not take the essential oil internally.

Self-help Uses Acidity & indigestion, p. 307; Morning sickness & nausea, p. 317; Stomach spasm, p. 305; Gas & bloating, p. 306.

Forsythia suspensa (Oleaceae) Weeping Forsythia, Lian Qiao (Chinese)

Description Deciduous shrub growing to 16 ft (5 m). Has toothed leaves, bright yellow flowers, and woody fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China and Japan, weeping forsythia is grown for its bright yellow blossoms in temperate gardens all over the world. The fruit is harvested in autumn, just before it is fully ripe.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents The fruit contains flavonoids, including rutin, lignans, glycosides, and forsythin. Research suggests that forsythin is antimicrobial, anti-emetic, and anti-inflammatory.

History & Folklore Weeping forsythia was first listed in the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ngong Bencaojing*), written in the 1st century CE. Weeping forsythia features in a remedy for infections devised in the 18th century.

Medicinal Actions & Uses A bitter-tasting, pungent herb with antiseptic and antiviral activity, weeping forsythia is used to treat infections such as colds, flu, sore throats, and tonsillitis. In traditional Chinese medicine, it is used to treat a range of other conditions (including boils, swollen glands, and skin infections). The American herbal scientist James A. Duke recommends it be taken as a warm tea, combined with honeysuckle (*Lonicera* spp., p. 229) and lemon balm (*Melissa officinalis*, p. 113), at the onset of colds and similar viral infections.

Caution Not advisable in pregnancy.

Fragaria vesca (Rosaceae) Wild Strawberry

Description Low-growing perennial herb spread by runners. Has 3-lobed leaves, white flowers, and small red berries.